

Learning French — what nobody tells you.

A method born from experience, not from a textbook.

B2+ in under 2 years — self-taught, no formal classes, while managing an asylum case and building our life here.

01

The decision — before everything else

The foundation of everything

Before the apps, the courses, the YouTube videos — there is a decision to make. Not an intention. A decision. Like quitting smoking. Like losing weight. You know you have to do it, you know it will be hard, and you decide to do it anyway — unconditionally, without delay, without valid excuses.

For us, it was not a question. We lived in a village where almost nobody spoke English or Spanish. French was not an option — it was the only way out. That constraint was our best teacher.

THE TRUTH NOBODY TELLS YOU

Most immigrants who do not learn French are not lacking resources — they are lacking a decision. Free courses exist everywhere in France. Free apps. Unlimited online content. The problem is never access. It is will. And will does not come from motivation — it comes from a firm decision, made once, never questioned again.

02

Passive immersion — before you understand anything

From day one

The first thing we did — before even understanding a word — was listen to French constantly. French music, French radio, podcasts, films. Without trying to understand everything. Just to get the brain used to the sounds, the rhythm, the music of the language.

It may seem pointless at first. It is not. Your brain works even when you are not aware of it. One day, a word you have heard a hundred times suddenly makes sense. That is the moment the language starts to get in.

WHAT WORKED FOR US

French music first — it is everywhere, it is free, and it connects words to emotions. Your brain retains far better what moves it. Then films and series with French subtitles — not Spanish, not English. French. You will read faster than you understand — and that is exactly what accelerates learning.

03

The tools — free and effective

In parallel with immersion

Tools do not replace real experience — but they build the foundation. Here are the ones that worked for us.

Duolingo [App — Free]

Simple, accessible, progressive. 15 minutes a day is enough to build basic vocabulary.

Online teachers [YouTube — Free]

Teachers who explain French in Spanish or English. Search 'learn French for Spanish speakers' or 'French for beginners'.

Google Translate [Daily tool]

Not to replace learning — to survive the first weeks. A temporary crutch, not a permanent solution.

Association classes [In person — Free]

In almost every village in France, associations offer free classes. Ask at the town hall.

WHAT NOBODY TELLS YOU

The tool matters less than consistency. 15 minutes every day is worth more than 3 hours on Sunday. French settles in through repetition, not through intense and occasional effort.

04

Speaking — even with a terrible accent

The only unavoidable step

This is the step everyone puts off. The fear of speaking badly, of making a fool of yourself, of not being understood. That fear is normal. It only disappears by going through it.

We started with the simplest interactions — saying hello at the supermarket, asking the price at the market, thanking someone in the street. Ten-word sentences at most. With Google Translate in our pocket for emergencies. With an accent that made people smile. And every single time, it worked.

WHAT NOBODY TELLS YOU

French people appreciate the effort. Far more than you think. An immigrant who tries to speak French — even very badly — will always be better received than one who does not try. The accent is not the problem. The silence is. Every failed conversation is a lesson you cannot buy.

THE MOST COMMON MISTAKE

Staying only with fellow countrymen. Speaking your native language all day and using French only when forced. That is the surest path to staying stuck at the same level for years. We have seen it in immigrants who have been in France for 5, 8 years — isolated, no French, no network. The comfort of your own language has an enormous cost.

05

Certification — make your level official

When you are ready

Once you have a solid level, get it certified. The DELF (Diplome d'Etudes en Langue Francaise) is recognized by all French administrations. A B1 or B2 in your file changes the weight of your application.

WHAT NOBODY TELLS YOU

Certification is not only for administrations. It is for you. Having a document that proves your level gives you a different kind of confidence — and it shows in the way you present yourself to an employer, an elected official, a neighbor. We obtained our B2+ in under two years. That document had more impact on our file than any other piece.

"The language of a country is its outstretched hand. If you take it — everything becomes possible. If you ignore it — everything becomes difficult."

There is no shortcut. But there is a method — and it works. Decide. Immerse yourself. Use the tools. Speak. Repeat. That is all.

Sur la bonne voie — Aubenas, Ardeche — 2026

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